

ENGLAND TOUR TO TEST INDIA'S NEW BATTLING ORDER

With the combined **experience of 190 Tests** gone with Virat Kohli and Rohit Sharma, India faces a steep and uncertain transition.

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India's vaunted 'next-gen' stars, bred on an overdose of T20 cricket, will be tasked with filling the void left by the last decade's most celebrated cricketers — Virat Kohli and Rohit Sharma — and preparing for life after them in the most testing format.

They will be thrown in at the deep end, beginning with a five-match Test series in England, which comes close on the heels of the Indian Premier League (IPL). A fledgling set of batters will be compelled to shelve flair for the hard grind in conditions where a Test series victory has been elusive since 2007. Add to that the absence of a cumulative experience of 190 Test matches, which Kohli and Rohit brought to the table, and all signs point towards a bumpy transition.

The recent rut in Tests, beginning with a shock whitewash at home against the Kiwis and followed by a 1-3 defeat in Australia, does not inspire confidence. But

Yashasvi Jaiswal and K.L. Rahul emerged as silver linings in times of crisis, establishing themselves as reliable openers for the future during the tour Down Under after Rohit missed the series opener in Perth. While Jaiswal was India's top scorer on his maiden tour of Australia, Rahul was the foil to the youngster's natural aggression. Rohit dropping down to No. 6 on his return in Adelaide and Rahul retaining his opening spot for the following two Tests was perhaps an indication that the skipper's days in the longest format were numbered, before his decision to axe himself from the final Test in Sydney meant the die was cast. A tally of 164 runs in his last 15 Test innings at an average of 10.93 would have only precipitated the announcement to finally call it a day.

Dealing with Rohit's retirement alone would not have set off too many alarm bells. But Kohli hanging up his boots has thrown hallowed land into disarray. Ever since Sachin Tendulkar stepped out at No. 4 in 1992 against Australia, before Kohli stepped into the breach in 2013, the solid bridge between the top and middle order has been the

India's potential top seven in England

Batter	Overall Tests	Tests in England	Overall Average
Yashasvi Jaiswal	19	0	52.88
K. L. Rahul	58	9	33.57
Shubman Gill	32	3	35.05
Sai Sudharsan	—	—	—
Rishabh Pant	43	9	42.11
Ravindra Jadeja	80	12	34.74
Nitish Kumar Reddy	5	0	37.25